Primary Chords and Chord Symbols

The triads on degrees 1, 4, and 5, the tonic, subdominant, and dominant, are the **primary chords** of a key, written I, IV, and V. In a major key all three are major triads. Together they contain every note of the scale, so they can accompany a great many melodies.

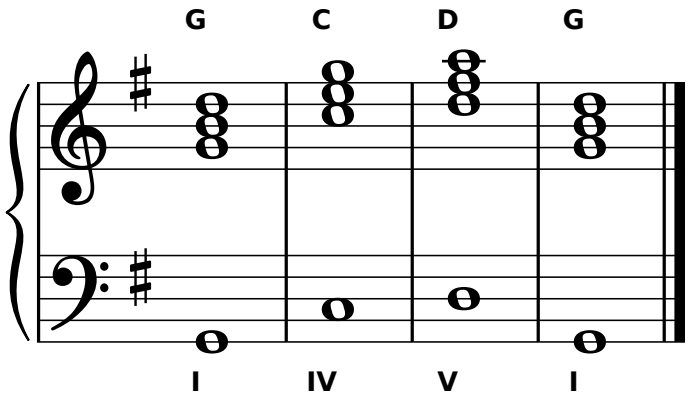
To find the primary chords of a key, count up from the tonic: I is built on degree 1, IV on degree 4, and V on degree 5. Each triad uses the notes of the key, so in G major the V chord is D, F♯, A, with the F♯ from the key signature.

The table shows the primary chords of the seven keys in this book, written as chord symbols.

Key	I	IV	V
C major	C	F	G
G major	G	C	D
D major	D	G	A
A major	A	D	E
F major	F	B♭	C
B♭ major	B♭	E♭	F
E♭ major	E♭	A♭	B♭

Cadences

A **cadence** is a pair of chords that ends a musical phrase. The move from V to I sounds finished and is the strongest cadence in music. The progression I–IV–V–I below ends with it. Chord symbols above the staff name each chord; Roman numerals below show its place in the key.



I–IV–V–I in G major. The left hand plays each root; the right hand plays the triad.

Reading chord symbols

Songbooks and lead sheets often print only a melody and chord symbols. A player reads the symbol, builds the triad from its root, and plays it as a solid or broken chord: **G** means G, B, D; **Am** means A, C, E; **B♭** means B♭, D, F.

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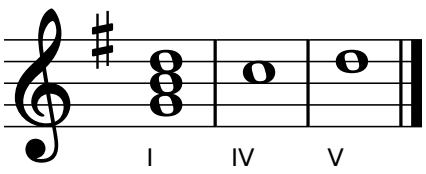
Name _____ Date _____

Primary Chords and Review

A. Write the primary chords Add the third and fifth above each root to write I, IV, and V. The key signature supplies the sharps and flats.

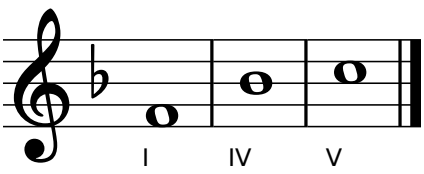
G major

EXAMPLE 1. 2.



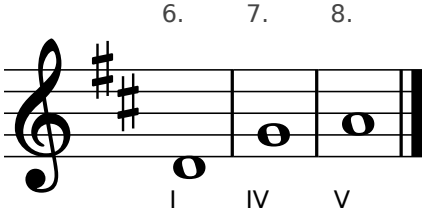
F major

3. 4. 5.



D major

6. 7. 8.



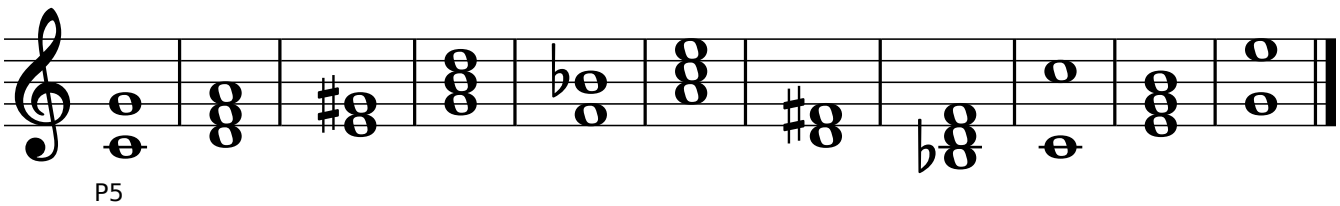
B. Primary chord symbols Write the chord symbol for each chord.

EXAMPLE IV in D major: G

1. V in A major: _____
2. I in E♭ major: _____
3. V in F major: _____
4. IV in B♭ major: _____
5. V in G major: _____
6. IV in A major: _____
7. V in E♭ major: _____
8. IV in C major: _____
9. V in D major: _____

C. Review Name each interval (such as M3) or triad (such as Dm).

EXAMPLE 1. 2. 3. 4. 5. 6. 7. 8. 9. 10.



P5 _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

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